

And then there were five! This time last year we had no idea that Penny would have another darling boy, Eric More Street. He is 11 days old in the picture below.



His clever Aunty Kay sent an Eric car for our Christmas train that she and Uncle Wayne had given us in 2008.

We were fortunate prior to the New Arrival on 19 November to have had a good year. In January Margery bought a new toy: the Kawai K8 upright (largest Kawai upright) and it will be a challenge to play to its potential.



Also in January Gavin, Penny, Jack and Molly c a m p e d alongside the Hawkesbury River at Mitchell Park. Lovely and uncrowded!



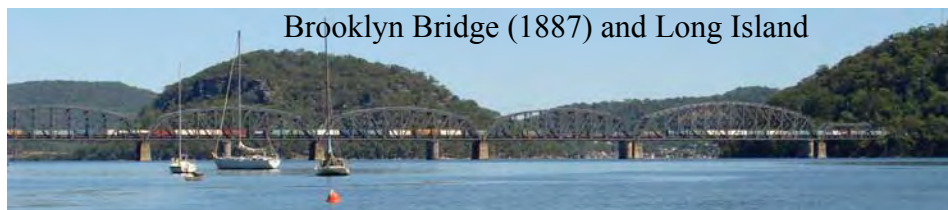
You may think we eat cake all the time. No! Oscar and Jack started school; Ross' PhD students David and Tom dutifully photographed the Streets Ice Cream signs during a Maths conference in Genova;



Snakes alive! Sam's 3rd



and we took Sam and Molly on the Hawkesbury River Ferry to Dangar Island to play near the Brooklyn Railway Bridge to Long Island. It was constructed by the Union Bridge Company of Brooklyn, New York.



Brooklyn Bridge (1887) and Long Island



Dangar Island

If you haven't been to Sydney Olympic Park and its various smaller parks on the south bank of the Parramatta River and Homebush Bay, do go. Thirty-five kilometres of safe and scenic cycling, "monster" BMX and Mountain X tracks for the brave and nimble, and clean undercover BBQs, tables and playgrounds. We celebrated a birthday taking in the Sunday tourist train around Newington Armoury, used to store armaments for the US and Royal Navies in WWII¹, and kids scootered and cycled around Wentworth Common. The "beehive" in the background is a cycle track spiraling up a hill very likely constructed to cover industrial waste in preparation for the 2000 Olympics. There's a view of the River from its summit.



Wentworth Common at Sydney Olympic Park in the rain



May and June were travel months. The Opera Hotel in Oslo was close to the fast train direct to the airport; bicycles were readily available in the city square below our window; the marble-tiled roof of the new Opera House was designed for walking on, although an escaped stroller or wheelchair might hurtle down its slope into the Oslo Fjord! It was wonderful to be in that city again after fifty years (yes!) and to visit a friend of many years. That is, after a friendly tram driver, seeing us bewildered on the tram station at the wrong end of town, explained that a foot race through Oslo meant the trams were coming into town and going right back out again instead of following their normal route through the city!

Pictured: "the intuitive launch of genius into space."²

http://www.sopa.nsw.gov.au/our_park/history_and_heritage/

naval_history

² in the words of Vigeland, its sculptor. Margery couldn't recall seeing the statue of the brilliant Norwegian mathematician Niels Abel in the Vigeland sculpture park in 1961. Probably because it was in the Royal Palace gardens!



Bergen is as charming as its reputation. We trundled our luggage up and down (often wet) cobblestone footpaths. Here's a glimpse of the MS Kong Harald in Bergen where it starts its northern journey up past the Arctic Circle: we scored a cabin next to the car deck just above the waterline ☺ - ah well, it was clean and comfortable with ensuite and porthole. While the Hurtigruten shipping/passenger line may be overrated,

an unsung gem just a tramride from Bergen is the residence and museum of Edvard Grieg (composer of "Home of the Mountain King" from Peer Gynt and "Arietta").



Piano-harp at Ringve Museum

We found several gems in Trondheim, owing to the hospitality of Prof Nils and Vivien Baas; don't miss the Cathedral, the Ringve Music



Museum or the views of city, mountains and fjord. Here's the view from Mathematics at the University of Science and Technology - I think Norway respects education!

We always look forward to Odense, Denmark, where Alison's children's houses are within walking distance of one another. Susie and Marcus served a traditional breakfast at her new house.



Susie, Marcus, and breakfast!

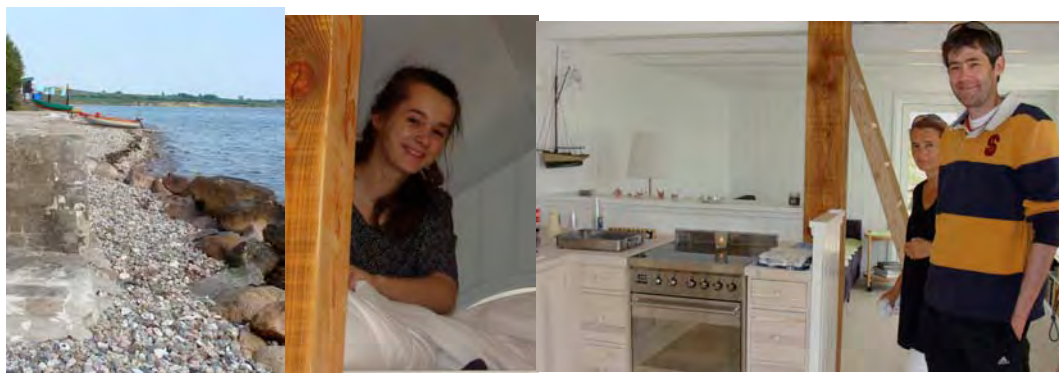
Then we were whisked down to the south coast where Thomas and Mette have rebuilt a waterside summerhouse in a heritage area east of Fåborg.



Susie, Marcus, Alison, Thomas, Freja and Ross at Susie's

Andrea showed us her award-winning film “My Brother who art in Heaven” starring Marcus and Freja.

The south coast view of Fyn from the new summer house; Andrea, Mette and Thomas inside.



The very next day Birte prepared a delicious lunch on their upstairs balcony overlooking the same body of water, but from the south, from the island of Æerø. We had fish freshly smoked on the island, followed by brisk walking past colourful beach houses and wading in the sea. Alec showed us his new project, the large old hotel in Æerøskøbing, soon to be an upmarket restaurant, hotel and events and cultural venue!



View from the hotel



Lunch for all & Australian wine



Birte at home on Æerø

The island of Æerø, (on the same latitude as Labrador, Canada) generates 80% of its heat and electricity from solar power³ - so what's the matter with Oz given its antipodean sunshine????

The next day Ross flew safely (after some drama finding the right train carriage at Odense station) to Brussels. Marino Gran met him and drove him back to Louvain-la-Neuve to prepare for his Chaire de la Vallée Poussin 2011 lectures. I followed a few days later having been held up at Copenhagen by the Grimsvotn volcano in Iceland. Sound familiar? Well, this only delayed 500 flights, not comparable with Eyjafjallajökull last year that cancelled 100,000 flights and stranded our Danish friends in Sydney for a week.⁴

³ http://www.aeroeisland.com/about_aero.php

⁴ Believe it or not, three weeks later a volcano in Chile's Puyehue-Cordon Caulle stranded people in Perth, Western Australia, while we were there!

Ross' lectures were well received. While he was working hard in the Mathematics Department, Isabella Fontana walked with me (one can walk everywhere in Louvain-la-Neuve) to one of the city's treasures: the 2009 museum designed for *Tintinophiles*. Louvain-la-Neuve claims Hergé⁵ as their own. The architecture allows wide views of the countryside with comfortable areas to absorb Hergé's works and character.



Francis and Christiane Borceux picked us up early on Saturday morning for a tour of four Flemish cities they knew well. Francis is an accomplished tour guide, able to speak in several languages on the history of Belgium and the curiosities of its cities' buildings.

In the centre of Bruges Brugge), a 12th



Christiane and Francis



century Basilica of the Holy Blood houses a relic which when touched, forgives all sins. The priest, who happens to be a woman, wipes the vial after each supplicant. As Ross remarked, our sins are still with us as we did not join the slow queue. Ross ate waterzooi for lunch.



Ghent (Gent) is at the confluence of the Scheldt and the Lys rivers. As in Bruges, canals are an attraction. Ghent has been famous for cloth, given the frequent flooding and use of land for sheep grazing. St Bavo's Abbey from AD 650 houses the twelve van Eyck panels of "The Adoration of the Lamb of God". Margery ate rabbit for dinner.

"Antwerp" may derive from the myth of Brabo (Brabant) who defeated the giant who exacted a toll for crossing the river Scheldt. Brabo cut off Antigoon's hand and flung it into the river - the brandished hand now a symbol of free waterways. Or it could be a Celtic word for billabong (Aboriginal for a loop

⁵ "Hergé" is Georges Remi's pseudonym. Reverse his initials and in French it sounds like "air-zhay". According to [UNESCO Index Translationum](#), Hergé is the ninth most often translated French language author, the second most often translated Belgian author after [Georges Simenon](#), and the second most often translated French language comics author behind [René Goscinny](#). [1652 Hergé](#), an [asteroid](#) of the [main belt](#), is named after him [<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hergé>]. Steven Spielberg's 3D movie "The Adventures of Tintin: The Secret of the Unicorn" opens in Sydney on Boxing Day.

detached from a river). Our hosts' chosen cozy restaurant "Le Zoute Zoen" means salt and sweet - the land was once covered by the sea. Salmon mousse.

Last stop was Brussels. Francis has recounted the histories and grandeur of each city. This child, inspired by the statue of "Manneken Pis", has drunk too much chocolate. Margery ate horse at 'T Kelderke on the Grand Place. Safely back to Louvain-la-Neuve.



Two days later Marino and Isabella drove us to Villers-la-Ville where Francis and Christiane waited in the drizzling rain to tour a 12th century abbey. Abbots lived in luxury while monks less so, and lay brothers did the work. The abbey's water mill supplied the famous Trappist beer, produced by monasteries as a healthier drink than water.

The hospitality of everyone we met was overwhelming. Still it was nice to get home. Two weeks later we flew to Fremantle (near Perth, Western Australia) for the wedding of Penny's brother Robyn, and Jo. Pictured below are Jack, Ring Boy; Molly, Flower Girl; Ross; Robyn, the Bridegroom; Margery; Gavin; Molly and Penny.



Jo was resplendent in traditional bridal dress in the Gothic Revival style St Patrick's Basilica, followed by a Wedding Breakfast in the Esplanade⁶ Hotel.

We hired a car to explore the gems of southwestern Western Australia. For example, heading south toward Margaret River there's a boardwalk for viewing thrombolites

⁶ The Esplanade is to Fremantle what the Bellport Dock is to Bellport: tourists and locals migrate to the spacious, tree-canopied park where families meet and enjoy the waterside.



and stromatolites in the sea. Pictured are domed thrombolites just below the surface, common 600 million years ago, and now a Critically Endangered Ecological Community. Formed by photosynthetic cyanobacteria precipitating calcium carbonate from the lime-rich brackish water of the perched Lake Clifton, they contributed to the planet's oxygen supply.



Calothamnus quadrifidus
Cape Naturaliste

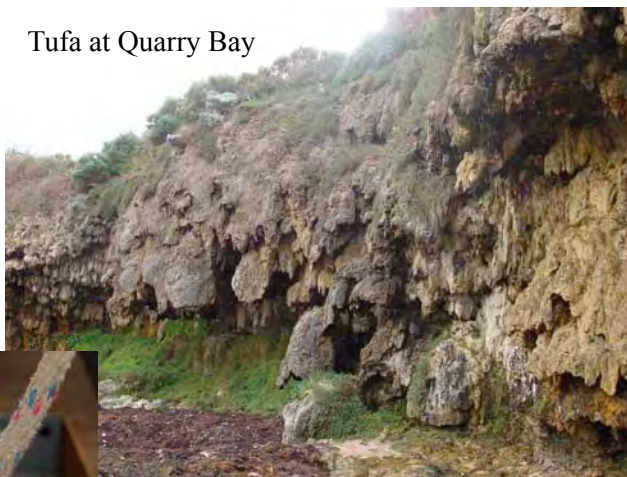
The commonest flowers are mind-exploding when you're used to East Coast species.

Remember last year we sent you photos of "tufa"⁷ from Lawn Hill Gorge in Queensland? The guide at the Cape Leeuwin lighthouse let us know it was forming nearby.

Gary Muir's
W O W

cruise on Nornalup and Walpole Inlets is environmental and cultural theatre. Stay at Don and Marge's Riverside Retreat Chalets. Don showed us his Model A restoration done under the watchful eye of birds building a nest in the ropes suspended above!

Tufa at Quarry Bay



In August the Australian Plants Society - New South Wales held its annual state-wide function in Wellington, in the

Central Tablelands four hours northwest of Sydney. Visionary locals conceived the idea of an Australian native collection in the 1930s and were eventually entrusted in 1964 with a weed-infested paddock opposite the new Burrendong Dam (reservoir formed when the Macquarie River was dammed). After devastating fire and hail storms came the secret plan to build an airfield! By the '70s when voluntary work had begun, there was threat of a road bisecting the land. A garbage tip was also proposed. We were impressed with the paths and signage; the meticulous record-keeping of every plant, dead or alive; the irrigation systems, the 5500m² shade canopy constructed by landscape students with donated metal wire,

⁷ Tufa forms in areas where groundwater seeps out through limestone. The resulting material is colonised by a variety of algae and bacteria, forming a living structure. This example is found at the southern end of the Cape to Cape walk, "growing" from the marine shoreline cliff at Quarry Bay. It was tricky to find.

and the planning and hospitality of the Plants Society. When you visit don't miss the Wellington Caves or nearby Mount Arthur and its narrow rough Burrunggee (*Take Care*) Trail that wraps around the eastern side to afford nice views.

Next year I'll tell you about our local Plants Society's hosting of the function!

I'll wrap this up with two events on the same weekend 19-20 November. Ross and Margery drove south to Wirrimbirra Sanctuary, home of the naturally-occurring white waratah, in Bargo. Wirrimbirra is owned, with no small controversy, by the National Trust; and as you might imagine by now, the actual work is done by volunteers. Our local Australian Plants group then regrouped on the top of Mt Gibraltar, 863m high. It is a collapsed volcanic core composed of hard Mt Gibraltar trachyte or *microsyenite*, quarried for road and building construction until 1986. Now you can admire the flora and views toward the west and north as far as Katoomba in the Blue Mountains. We set out on Saturday the 19th to make our third attempt at the Box Vale Track along a disused coal-tramway. It became clear that Eric was on his way, and so were we!! ***So I'll end where we started, with magnificent little Eric entering the world.***

Ross writes: It is a privilege still to have bright students wishing to do category theory. Micah McCurdy, David Oury and Tom Booker submitted PhD theses this year, Tom just on 15 December. Micah (principal supervisor Dominic Verity) and David now have their degrees and jobs. Our Irish son, John Bourke submitted in 2010 but it was approved in the year of which we account; his principal supervisor was Steve Lack. A Masters student Basile Pillet from Brittany France was also a joy to supervise for a couple of months mid year; see <<http://www.math.mq.edu.au/~street/Tanglewithcats.pdf>> and <<http://www.math.mq.edu.au/~street/PilletRapport.pdf>> to share his enthusiasm.

Many of the items mentioned by Margery also apply to me. I am very proud of all the Grandad stuff. But it means my report can be much shorter! In particular, Margery has mentioned our trip to Belgium. My doings can be extracted from <<http://www.uclouvain.be/15551.html>> and <<http://perso.uclouvain.be/tim.vanderlinden/ctag.html>>. In introducing my talks I was embarrassed by Francis Borceux quoting from my retirement poem with chorus: "Thirty seven year, five day".

My 100th paper was published this year. Paper 113 is now in train. See <<http://www.math.mq.edu.au/~street/Publications.htm>> for the full list.

The Centre of Australian Category Theory (CoACT) which I still direct had a very strong year with research and teaching. Let me mention two wonderful items. Congratulations to Steve Lack (now Associate Professor at Macquarie) for winning a Future Fellowship funded for four years by the Australian Research Council. Dominic Verity received a citation for Outstanding Contribution to Student Learning by the Australian Learning and Teaching Council.

*With love and greetings to all, Ross
and Margery*

